have changed anything? Should I have been there, trying to be the glue keeping them together? I couldn't help but question myself. It would have been pretty impossible to be with them more often: I was in Manchester most of the week and the odd day or two off I needed to be with Victoria and the boys. Even if there had been more time, would me being around have made the difference? Looking back, I don't think so.

Even after it's happened, now Mum and Dad are divorced, it's still hard for me. Hard for Lynne and Joanne, too. It's not necessarily said in as many words but there's always, in these situations, a question: whose side are you on? For me and my sisters, that isn't even something we think about: they're our mum and dad and 'sides' doesn't come into it. But I can see that, for parents, there'd be insecurity. They're having a painful time, feeling guilty themselves and they don't want to lose a family at the same time as they lose a husband or wife. I see Mum a lot because she helps us with looking after the boys. I can see that Dad might feel that there's more to it than that. The only way we'll ever get round 'whose side are you on', I think, is if Mum and Dad can find a way to talk to one another again, find a new kind of relationship where there's a bit of trust between them. I really hope that will happen.

I really don't believe I could have stopped them splitting up but I did want to do what I could to make it easier for each of them after it happened. I helped buy our family home—the house I grew up in—so Dad could make his new start there. I needed to be sure my mum felt settled and I know my Nan and Grandad were worried about her too. I bought Mum a new place out in Loughton, nearer to the house in Sawbridgeworth, where she could live with Joanne. I'd always imagined that, somewhere down the line, I'd have bought them a big house somewhere to live in together. My parents were married nearly thirty years; I still can't come to terms with the idea that they're set up now for living apart. For us—me, Lynne and Joanne—and for them, I hope that, somewhere down the line they'll become friendly enough, at least, for us all to sit down together to remember some of the great times we had.

How could it all not have made me think about my own family? The story of my parents' marriage makes me feel sad, empty inside. What was home isn't any more. Who can tell what lies down the road for you in your own life? At home with Victoria and the boys is where I feel I'm fulfilled. My marriage and my family are precious to me. So precious I don't know what life would be about without them. I want to see our children grow up. I want me and Victoria to grow old in each other's company, the two of us together always. I married just this once and I want it to mean what it does now, forever. Mum and Dad separating has made me even more aware of that.